



might have been representations of magical objects given to the gods such as Thor's hammer and Odin's spear. Thor's hammer, called Mjöllnir, was his main weapon, which would magically return to his hand after he hurled it at an enemy. Thunder was believed to be the sound of his hammer smashing his foes. But the hammer symbol was said to give its bearer protection and strength. It often appeared with the *sólarhvél* (sun wheel), which looks similar to the ancient sign known as the swastika and was said to bring good luck and prosperity.

Perhaps the most mysterious and powerful sign was the Helm of Awe, with its eight radiating arms like barbed tridents. It was supposed to ensure victory for the wearer and strike fear into enemies, as these lines from the Norse saga *Fáfnismál* describe: "The Helm of Awe, I wore before the sons of men, In defense of my treasure; Among all, I alone was strong, I thought to myself, For I found no power a match for my own."

▲ Magical symbol

This is part of a picture stone almost 6½ ft (2 m) tall now set into the wall of a church in Bro, Gotland, Sweden. Legend has it that a nearby well was a sacrificial site. The stone dates from the 5th century BCE and this detail looks like an elaborate sun wheel, a lucky symbol linked with Thor and representative of the earth, its relation to the sun, and to the cosmos as a whole.